founded the Ava dynasty near modern Mandalay at the meeting of the Ayeyarwaddy and Myitnge Rivers. It wasn't until the reign of Thadominpaya (r. ca. 1364–1368) that Ava controlled Upper Burma and to which the kingdom is dated. Ava used their geographical location on the eastern bank of the Ayeyarwaddy to exploit Chinese overland trade as well as Indian Ocean commerce. Following the Mongol destruction of the kingdom of Dali in the late 13th century, a migration of ethnic Shan tribes from the mountains of southern Yunnan into the Nam Mao valley and surrounding region filled the void left by the fall of the Bagan kingdom. The period following the collapse of the kingdom of Bagan was characterized by constant warfare between Ava and Pegu, and to a lesser extent between Ava and the Shan principalities as Ava sought to reassert suzerainty over Burma. Ava briefly controlled Arakan (1379–1420) and came close to defeating Pegu, but could never unify Burma again.

THE ORIGINS OF BAGAN

To this day the origins of Bagan remain unclear. Local chronicles suggests that a line of 55 kings ruled over Bagan for a period of 12 centuries. The chronicles go on to claim that Bagan was originally one of the group of 19 villages practicing wet-rice agriculture, and existing as a contemporary to the Pyū city-states of Beikthano, Halingyi, and Śrī Kşetra circa 107 CE. The difficulty with affixing a date this early in Burmese history is that it is not supported by either archaeological or epigraphical evidence.

Archaeological evidence as well as Bagan's location between Halingyi in the north and Śrī Kşetra in the south point suggest that Bagan had Pyū origins. The Burmans began migrating from Nan-Chou in present-day Yunnan to the Ayeyarwaddy valley in the sixth century. Over time the Burman established themselves at Bagan, gradually displacing the Pyū. When the Nan-Chou kingdom invaded and sacked Halingyi in ca. 832–835, it destroyed the last major Pyū center in Upper Burma, thereby creating a power vacuum into which the Burmans stepped, displacing Pyū influence. The local chronicles go on to state that it was Pyinbya (r. ca. 846–878) who built the present-day Bagan city wall in 849 CE following the transfer of the capital from Tampawady. By 874 CE, Bagan had become a major city and by the 11th century it was a burgeoning regional power in Southeast Asia.